

**SYNTHETIC TRAINING RECORD — FICTIONAL PARTIES, PEOPLE,
OFFICES, IDENTIFIERS, AND EVENTS — NOT A REAL FILING**

First Amended Complaint

United States District Court for the Eastern District of North Carolina

Rhea Calder v. Cinder Lake Health Network, Inc.

Civil Action No. SYN-EDNC-25-CV-0882

Docket Entry 4 — Filed December 12, 2025

Plaintiff Rhea Calder files this amendment as of right and alleges one federal retaliation count under 31 U.S.C. § 3730(h). The amendment clarifies dates, separates Calder's ordinary-business knowledge from Cinder Lake's attorney-led investigation, and attaches no privileged material. All people, entities, identifiers, and events are fictional.

Calder alleges that Cinder Lake terminated her after she reported suspected billing discrepancies and took steps aimed at stopping potential false claims. Cinder Lake has not admitted those allegations, and this pleading makes no finding on their truth.

Parties, Jurisdiction, and Venue

Calder was a compliance analyst at Cinder Lake's fictional Raleigh office. Cinder Lake is a fictional health network alleged to operate in this district and to participate in federal health-benefit programs. The Court has jurisdiction under 28 U.S.C. § 1331, and venue is alleged where the reporting and employment decisions occurred.

The amendment does not add a state-law claim or require application of state privilege law. Calder's single federal claim supplies the action's legal basis. Any later attorney-client-privilege dispute therefore arises under federal common law through Federal Rule of Evidence 501.

Calder's June 2025 Reports

Calder alleges that ordinary reconciliation work revealed repeated mismatches between billing summaries and supporting service documentation. On June 4 and June 18 she delivered reports to designated compliance recipients. On June 27 she answered questions in an intake interview and requested review independent of the affected reporting line.

The reports allegedly identified records, dates, and exception categories known to Calder from her employment. They did not include counsel's advice because the attorney-led review had not yet communicated any advice to Calder. Calder's firsthand account remains distinct from later privileged communications among Cinder Lake personnel and counsel.

Investigation and August 21 Response

Calder was told that outside counsel would coordinate a review. On August 21, 2025, Cinder Lake sent a response to a fictional federal health-program oversight office stating that outside counsel had reviewed Calder's reports and that the organization adopted identified remedial measures. The letter did not quote or summarize a communication from counsel, a witness interview, counsel's mental impressions, or legal analysis.

Calder relies on the letter only as a public-facing corporate statement about review and remediation. She does not allege that it revealed the advice underlying any action. Whether the letter disclosed privileged content, as opposed to nonprivileged conclusions and conduct, is not resolved by this pleading.

Employment Chronology

Calder alleges a July 18 performance notice, removal from recurring meetings during August, and termination on September 12, 2025. She says decision-makers knew of her reports and used performance criticisms not raised in earlier evaluations. She further alleges that the stated reasons changed after she challenged the notice.

Cinder Lake may contest each allegation. The chronology is offered to support knowledge and causation under § 3730(h), not to prove the truth of Calder's billing concerns or to make investigation files relevant without regard to privilege and proportionality.

Count One — Section 3730(h)

Calder alleges that her reports and related efforts were undertaken in furtherance of stopping suspected false claims, that Cinder Lake knew of those efforts, and that the organization retaliated through adverse employment actions. She seeks the statutory remedies available if those elements are proven.

The count does not plead reliance on counsel's advice, selective disclosure of an attorney communication, or a need for every internal-investigation document. Calder reserves ordinary discovery requests for relevant nonprivileged facts, custodial records, and witness testimony.

Distinct Information Sources

Calder identifies three nonprivileged sources: records created in the ordinary course, statements she personally made or received outside a request for legal advice, and the August 21 external response. She alleges those sources can test the retaliation claim without access to legal advice.

She also anticipates that Cinder Lake may possess interview notes, analysis, and communications created for counsel's review. The amendment does not concede that every such item is privileged or work product, but it recognizes that protection must be evaluated document by document and that merely sharing a topic does not make separate communications identical.

Relief and Signature

Calder requests judgment, lawful reinstatement or front pay, back pay, special damages, interest, reasonable fees and costs, and further appropriate relief. She demands a jury on triable issues. No relief is requested against a real person, company, or government office.

Submitted December 12, 2025 by **Nina Ashe**, fictional counsel for Rhea Calder. The amended pleading was served through the synthetic civil-filing channel on counsel designated for Cinder Lake Health Network, Inc.